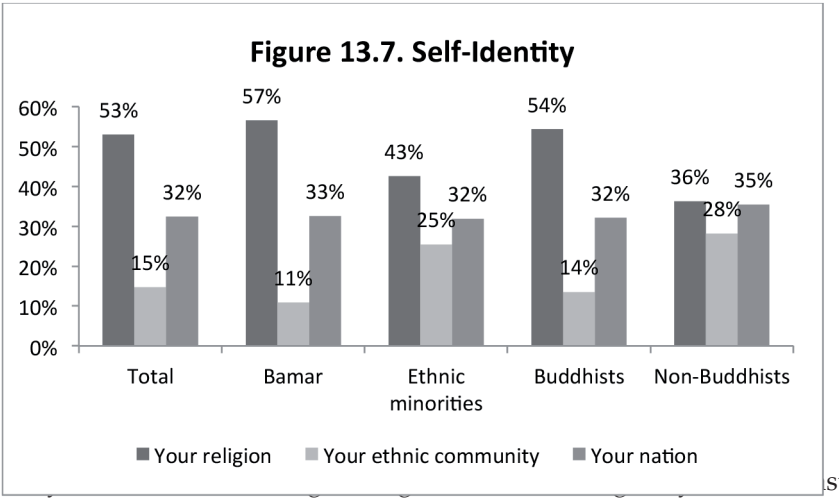
only eight per cent, with the large majority of respondents being Buddhist. Despite including religious minorities in all fieldwork teams, the number of Muslims interviewed only reached one per cent. This was one of the areas where the ABS's level of representativeness could have been stronger. We were unlucky in our randomly selected townships, capturing fewer Muslim dominant areas in Rakhine State, for example. We are, however, able to distinguish between Buddhists and non-Buddhists. For further understanding of the impact of religion, we also distinguish between those who self-identify as devout Buddhists compared to those who do not, capturing differences in religiosity as well.

The findings confirm that religion is an important marker of identity, even more prominent than ethnicity. As Figure 13.7 shows, fifty-two per cent of Myanmar citizens are most likely to prioritize religion over ethnicity or national affinity in how they identify themselves. Myanmar citizens were asked to differentiate between religion (bathadaya), race (lumyo), and Myanmar nationality (Myanma amyotha). In fact only fifteen per cent identify with their race first. A third of Myanmar citizens identified with the Myanmar nation. It is noteworthy that a quarter of ethnic minorities prioritized "Myanmar nation" over other markers. Identity is complex, as individuals often change their identity in different circumstances and experience multiple identities, so these results should be interpreted with caution. Nevertheless, the prioritization of religion shows how important it is in Myanmar society, relative to other commonly used markers.



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